Three's a Class

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Three's a Class

by DeltaFell

Summary

Catra is an ordinary college freshman at Etheria University, when a "site visit" - in her opinion, just a field trip, really - goes terribly, terribly wrong and Catra's world is turned upside down permanently. Secrets from her past that she thought long dead may start rising from the grave if she's not careful.

The Beginning

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra hated this class. It was so fucking boring. It was BIO 101, why was she here. She was an English major, it's not like she'd ever even use anything from this stupid class anyways. Etheria University required all freshmen to take a class considered a "First-Year Class," and since this one took care of her natural science Gen Ed. requirement, Catra had signed up for it, hoping to kill two birds with one stone. At least one of her roommates had the same section of this class. Entrapta might look like she was sleeping through class, but Catra knew that she always aced the tests anyways. If Hordak said anything important today she could just ask at the study session tomorrow night.

Catra could feel her focus fading, and she closed her eyes for just a minute. She'd rest her eyes a little, and then get back to doodling in her notebook.

"... three most common orders of Class Arachnida are Order Araneae - the order of Arachnida you're likely most familiar with, Spiders, Order Acari - Mites, and Order Scorpiones - Scorpions." Hordak said.

Catra groaned internally. She had fallen asleep, and now had no idea what in the hell Hordak was talking about. Looks like she'd be spending her night studying. Again. A shrill alarm split the air, and interrupted Catra's train of thought. Hordak jumped, actually jumped, and shuffled through his pockets before finding his phone and disabling the alarm.

“Crap, that’s all the time we have today. Remember, tomorrow we have a site visit to the Prime Labs. You can bring your phones, if you want, but you’ll have to sign an NDA to do so. If anybody shares anything you see inside, you’ll probably be expelled or something, and I’ll have to do paperwork.”

“Hey ‘Trapta, wake up, class is over.” Catra shook Entrapta’s shoulder gently.

“Mmm hmmm?” Entrapta said as she lifted her head and blinked rapidly.

“Lunchtime with Scorp over in Plumeria.”

“Oh, right! They have the miniature soups I love! They’re just so cute.” Entrapta perked right up, and grabbed her bag. She hadn’t even opened it all class.

“So, who’s your favorite superhero?” Scorpia asked between bites of her sandwich.

“Hmmm. Probably Major Wind. Her abilities to create miniature cyclones is fascinating! There’s just so much about weather that

we still don’t understand, perhaps by studying her powers we can gain new insights into the formation of such weather patterns!”

“What about you Catra, who’s your favorite superhero?”

“Oh, I dunno, I’m not really that big a fan of superheroes. They’re all like way older than us anyways, so I never kept track,” Catra said.

“C’mon Catra, surely you’ve got one superhero you like.”

“Nope, although, I can tell you one superhero I dislike. Light Spinner was a bitch. I met her once in middle school. Total jackass,” Catra said as she finished her drink.

Catra took her time walking about Prime Labs. She was careful to not fall behind the tour, but made certain she got a good look at the stuff that interested her. Without the tour guide guiding what she looked at, thank you very much. She wasn’t certain why, but she definitely didn’t trust their tour guide - who bore an uncanny resemblance to their TA, Hordak - to allow an unbiased view of everything she saw.

The tour guide, whose name tag read Wrong Hordak- seriously, who names their kid that- was talking about some of the

experiments they were running with spiders. Catra sighed. she had better at least look like she was trying to pay attention now. This was what they were here to learn about anyways.

"... Our experiments here have been mostly centered around the amazing webs of orb weaver spiders. We hope to learn how to replicate their strengths for our own benefits. Just imagine, a climbing rope as thin as a necklace, but as strong as steel. Picture a bike lock that weighs virtually nothing!"

Yeah, it was a load of marketing bullshit, of course. Catra tried to at least look focused, but she couldn't help it. It was all so boring. Her eyes started to wander, and then she felt a sharp pain on the back of her hand.

Sitting there, smug as could be, was a tiny little spider. It had a black body with metallic green fangs and white markings on its back. Before Catra could do anything, it jumped off into the lab and out of sight. Thanks to Entrapta's flash card session last night, she recognized it as a Daring Jumping Spider. Fortunately, she also knew that their bites were not only rare, but usually pretty much harmless.

For a minute, Catra considered telling Wrong Hordak a jumping spider had bitten her. But she remembered that he had just mentioned that they were working with orb weaver spiders, not jumping spiders, so this probably wasn't an escaped specimen. Besides, for some reason, she got the feeling that she shouldn't tell him.

The tour continued for some time, although Catra found it difficult to pay attention. That spider bite throbbed painfully, which made it even harder for her to focus than the boring material did. She decided to get Entrapta to look at it when they got back to the dorm. She might be able to tell if anything was off, or at least make something for it.

Another lab tech, one who also bore an unnerving resemblance to Hordak, approached Wrong Hordak. Catra couldn't make out whatever it was he said, but it must have been really bad, because Wrong Hordak paled further than Catra thought possible for someone already so pale. Wrong Hordak cut the tour off early, visibly flustered.

"Come on this way folks, unfortunately due to unforeseen circumstances we will be ending this tour early."

As they were leaving, Catra saw him hit an alarm on their way out, but it didn't sound while they were still inside. Man she really didn't feel good. What the hell was in that spider venom?

Catra had trouble sleeping that night. Either she was too cold, or she was too hot. She had a fever and the chills. She felt sick to her stomach too. Catra tossed and turned all night long. By the time the sun came up, Catra was still awake. She only barely crawled out of bed to send an email to her professors, explaining that she was too sick to come in today, and curled back up in her bed.

At one point in the day Scorpia came by to see how she was feeling.

"Wildcat? Are you okay in there?"

"Just peachy Scorpia. And don't call me Wildcat. It's probably just a little stomach bug," Catra lied.

"Right, right, okay Catra. I'll be back in a few hours to see how you're doing."

Why couldn't Scorpia just give her space. She was sick, she just wanted to be alone. It was a weird kind of sick, she did not want anyone to see her like this.

Things got weirder when she tried to get up. Her hands were stuck to her blanket. Catra shook her hands violently. They did not get loose.

"What the fuck? What's going on?"

Catra tried to stand up, but she tripped over the blanket and pitched face first into the wall. She jumped back, finally freeing herself from the blanket, but she had jumped much further than she had intended. Catra had managed to jump, and because it wasn't enough already, stick herself to the ceiling of her dorm room.

She could hear Entrapta and Scorpia talking down the hall. Oh boy this was bad, she had somehow managed to alert them. She had to get down somehow, she couldn't let them see her stuck to the ceiling. What would they think? Would they be mad? Hurt, that she hadn't told them she had superpowers?

The door opened, revealing Entrapta holding a lockpick in one hand and a tray of mini-soups in the other. Behind Entrapta stood a very nervous Scorpia, chewing on her fingernails.

"Oh, hello Catra," Entrapta said.

Shit.

"So, just to make sure I have everything straight, you were bitten by a strange spider while on the site visit to Prime Labs, didn't report it to anyone, started to feel bad really quickly, didn't sleep all of last night because you were feeling symptoms typical for victims of the Daring Jumping Spider, and now you can stick to things," Entrapta said.

"Yes, pretty much."

"Wait, you guys got to go on a field trip? Man, I wish I took that class. I haven't been on a field trip in ages."

“It wasn’t a field trip Scorpia, it was a site visit,” Entrapta said.

“It was pretty lame anyways, Scorp, you didn’t miss much.”

“Yes, it was quite disappointing, current circumstances notwithstanding.”

“Well, do you have any other superpowers? Ooh can you fly? Do you have invisibility, or super speed?” Scorpia asked.

“It’s not a superpower Scorpia, my hands stick to things and I can’t get them to come loose! Which is why I’m still stuck to the fucking ceiling!”

“It’s a superpower, Catra,” Entrapta said while tapping away at a tablet she pulled from somewhere, “besides, I believe she does also possess super strength now, unless you mean to tell us that jumping up to the ceiling like that is normal for you?”

“A fat lot of good it's doing me, as I still can’t get my hands off the ceiling.”

“Just try breathing, Wildcat. In for two, out for four,” Scorpia said.

“How the fuck is breathing supposed to help with my hands being stuck to the ceiling?”

“Well, it seems like this may be a response to your body feeling stressed. When you hit the wall and jumped up, your heart rate would have spiked and adrenaline would have flooded your system as your flight-or-fight response kicked in. It’s entirely possible that attempting to slow your heart rate through breathing would allow you to unstick.”

“Okay, I’ll try it. Anything’s better than staying stuck up here,” said Catra.

“Alright, breathe with me Wildcat. In for two, out for four. In for two, out for four.”

“Not helping, Scorpia. Just let me focus.”

Catra closed her eyes and gave a ragged exhale. In for two, out for four. Catra let the world fade away, and just focused on her breathing. In for two, out for four. She was fine, she was safe in her apartment, with both of her roommates nearby. In for two, out for four. She was safe.

One finger popped off the wall, but Catra kept her eyes closed and focused on her breathing. In for two, out for four. As she continued, her pulse lowered and her breathing steadied. A second finger came unstuck. In for two, out for four. This method was actually working pretty well, she’d have to thank Scorpia for it. In for two, out for four.

As she began to feel a third finger come loose, all of a sudden, Catra dropped from the ceiling and back onto her bed.

"Huh. That actually worked pretty well, for just breathing in and out," she said. "Thanks, Scorpia."

Catra sat on the roof of her dorm building, legs kicking off the edge. She'd always loved getting into places where she maybe shouldn't be as a kid, and she still did. Turns out having superstrength, and the ability to stick to walls, made doing so much easier.

It was peaceful up here. No roommates to pester her, no idiot down the hall trying to make thermite, just Catra and her thoughts. She definitely liked it here. Catra breathed deeply, enjoying the night air.

What was she going to do with her powers? That question had haunted her throughout the day. Entrapta and Scorpia were obviously very much in favor of her going out and becoming a superhero. How was that fair to her? She had college to worry about, and getting a job before next semester, unless Entrapta or Scorpia had a hidden nest egg they hadn't yet mentioned somehow and were also willing to part with so she could pay rent. Catra didn't have the time to be a superhero.

Shit, she was seriously considering this, wasn’t she. Even despite all the factors stacked against it, she was still considering becoming a superhero.

It’s what she would want her to do anyways. With a sigh, Catra stood up and walked over to the edge. She hopped off, sticking herself to the side of the building and making her way down.

Entrapta owed her a crate of the lime chili shrimp ramen for this one.

Chapter End Notes

Have you figured out the title yet? :)

I have finished writing Three's a Class, I started it in July, but I wanted to finish the whole fic before I started posting the chapters. I'm a little excited to be posting my first completed multi-chapter fic, although this may be the only multi-chapter work for a while, all that I have planned and written are single chapter fics.

Once again, thank you to everyone for reading, it really does make my day to see how many people click on my stories.

Girls' Day Out

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta and Scorpia are just so insistent on helping Catra become a superhero, much to her significant annoyance. Catra goes along with it, but before she can really protest, one of those buried secrets digs its way out.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra, Entrapta, and Scorpia stood around the counter in their dinky little apartment kitchen. Catra was trying to eat her bowl of oatmeal while the other two were busy planning out her superhero career for her.

"The first order of business, Scorpia, should be Catra's superhero identity," Entrapta said. "We need to determine a theme, and keep it sufficiently distinct from Catra so as to prevent detection."

"So what kind of theme should she have, do you think? She has superstrength and can stick to walls. What kind of theme goes with that," Scorpia said.

"Well, we could do a spider motif, since she was bitten by a spider. How about the Web Weaver? It's catchy, fits the spider theme, and even has alliteration!"

“No. Nothing with the word Weaver in it,” Catra said. She glared at Entrapta and Scorpia over her bowl of oatmeal.

“What about Spiderwoman? It’s pretty simple, and cuts right to the point,” Scorpia said.

“I suppose it could do,” Entrapta said, clearly disappointed at the simple name.

“I like it,” Catra said.

“Spiderwoman it is then,” Entrapta said, tapping away at her datapad. “We’ll have to make you a suit, and perhaps some kind of gadget. How do you feel about stun cuffs? No cape, of course. Hmm, we should have at least one gadget that ties into the spider motif. I’ll have to think on it in the lab.”

“Wait, in the lab? I thought you were just going to, I dunno, make this here in the dorm.”

“I wasn’t planning to, no, not when I have access to far better facilities. Would you prefer I make them in the dorm? I can, but it would impact the quality of the work more than I would like.” Entrapta looked up at Catra questioningly.

“I, uh, no, the lab’s fine. I just didn’t know you had a lab.”

“Oh it's fantastic, would you like to see?”

“I’m sure it would be fascinating, but I have that journalism class today, so I don’t know if I can make it.”

“That’s the one where the professor lets you skip and gives bonus credit if you can get an interview, right?” Entrapta said.

“Uh, yeah, Netossa does that if we can get an interview with an important figure. Why?” said Catra.

“Well, if you want, I can get you a pretty high profile interview while we’re at the lab.”

“Is that, like, okay? I don’t want you getting into trouble on my behalf. If it’s too much hassle we can always go later.”

“Nonsense, it’s no trouble at all. Besides, I’ve been wanting to show you guys the lab for a while now.“

Not too long later the trio stood downtown, in front of the Dryl Industries tower. Catra and Scorpia exchanged a look.

“Okay, I knew you were smart, Entrapta, but this is a whole ‘nother level. You work for Dyrl freaking Industries?”

“Well, what better interview to get you out of class than an exclusive piece with the CEO?”

“Wait, wait what? The reclusive, almost never seen CEO of Dryl Industries, will give me an exclusive interview on basically no notice, because you asked?”

“Yeah, pretty much.”

Scorpia let out a low whistle. “Damn, that’s some serious pull, ‘Trapta. You’re sure this won’t get you in any trouble at Dryl?”

“Yup,” Entrapta said, walking in the front door of Dryl Industries.

Catra and Scorpia exchanged another incredulous look. Catra just shrugged and followed after Entrapta.

Inside, the Dryl Industries tower lobby was a bustling hub of activity. Engineers and scientists rushed from one point to another. Interns and delivery people bearing food-laden trays filled the elevators. Security guards could be seen flanking every entrance, and many other doors, including what looked to be an unmarked elevator.

Entrapta led the trio towards the unmarked elevator. As she approached the two guards, they both straightened

simultaneously. They both wore military style plate carriers, and their holsters both held large sidearms. The woman, whose curly green hair was held back by a hairband had a nametag on her plate carrier which read Baker.

"Good morning, sir," Baker said.

"Good morning Baker! Do you know where Emily is today?" Entrapta said.

"She should be in the penthouse suite currently, Ms. Dryl," Baker said, after consulting her phone. "Do you want me to search those two?"

"No, they're friends. Baker, Soda Pop, this is Catra and Scorpia, my roommates. Catra, Scorpia, this is Baker and Soda Pop, two of my friends from before college and guards at Dryl Industries."

"Damn E, I was beginning to think they weren't even real!" Soda Pop said. "It's nice to meet you two finally. Entrapta's spoken quite highly of you two."

"Uh, hi, it's nice to meet you," Catra said, shifting from foot to foot..

"C'mon guys, let's get to the lab and see Emily," Entrapta said, pulling Catra and Scorpia along before Scorpia could embrace

Baker and Soda Pop in a hug.

Once they were in the elevator, Entrapta addressed Scorpia, "Baker and Soda Pop will probably not appreciate being hugged unexpectedly, so please warn them before you go in for a hug."

"Oh, uh okay. That's pretty thoughtful of you Entrapta, thank you for telling me," Scorpia said, a little taken aback.

As the penthouse suite doors opened, Catra was awestruck by the sheer size of the penthouse suite. It really occupied a whole floor of the Dryl Industries tower. How the other side lives indeed. Who even needs a living room the size of her entire freaking dorm?

"Hey Emily, we're here!" Entrapta shouted.

Catra looked askance at Entrapta. What was her relationship with the CEO of Dryl Industries where she could just show up unannounced with guests, walk into her home, and shout her first name?

From a room Catra couldn't see, a loud crashing noise could be heard, as if some massive machine had fallen from a table. Rapid clanging noises like giant footfalls began to approach. Suddenly very concerned, Catra prepared to grab Scorpia and Entrapta and

bust out the window. She could probably stick to the side of the building and make her way down. Probably.

A massive green ball shot out of one of the hallways towards Entrapta. Catra sprung into action, but Entrapta actually leaped towards this mystery cannonball.

"Emily!" she shouted, hugging the giant green ball that now sported legs, having come to a stop just before impacting Entratpa at full speed.

"What the fuck is going on?" Catra said. "I thought Emily was the CEO, but instead she's your robotic pet? Entrapta, explain yourself."

"What? No, Emily's not the CEO of Dryl Industries. I am."

"If you have all this," Catra gestured at the impressive suite, "then why the hell are you living in a shitty ass dorm with Scorpia and I? And also, why are you attending college, it's not like you need it for anything?"

"Well, after Dryl Industries really started being self-sufficient, I decided that the best way to keep learning was to go through college and pursue a Ph.D. Unfortunately, I have to go through undergraduate first. I chose to live in the dorms because I wanted a good way to meet new people. I'd say that certainly worked out for me, I made two new friends!"

“Aww, that’s so sweet of you Entrapta!” Scorpia said.

“We can talk interview later, for now let’s get down to the lab,” Entrapta said.

“So, Catra, here are some of the ideas I’ve had. First off, to tie you more strongly to the spider motif, wrist mounted web shooters. This synthetic spider silk is incredibly lightweight, but also super strong! My next idea is a spider mouth with gripping mandibles in case you need to hold onto something, perhaps some web line, but also need full use of your hands for something else, say fighting bad guys. Thirdly, and last for now, is your suit. A spider icon on the front and back would help again to tie you to your motif. I prepared multiple different models in different colors. The eyes will all change shape and adjust to the lighting incredibly rapidly so you can’t get blinded by sudden changes in luminosity.”

“The first one sounds really cool honestly, but the spider mouth looks kinda creepy. Aren’t superheroes supposed to, I dunno, look friendly? I don’t want to get shot by a cop or someone I’m trying to save ‘cause my mouth looked too scary,” Catra said.

“Are there any suits you like, Wildcat?” said Scorpia.

“I kinda like the black and red one. I think it looks pretty cool.”

“Okay, I’ll get those running through the production line right away! We should have them done later tonight! In the meantime, do you want to have a sleepover in the penthouse suite?”

“Oh fuck yes,” said Catra

“Catra…” said Scorpia

“What, it's a sick ass penthouse. Don’t tell me you didn’t want to at least spend the night.”

Scorpia didn’t respond, merely shooting her a look.

‘My Roommate, My Friend, Entrapta Dryl’

Catra stared at the article on her laptop. 10,000 words, holy shit. She hit save one more time, just to be certain, and then opened up her email. She attached the document to her already written draft. She really hoped that Professor Netossa liked the article, she didn’t want to get another talking-to from her. That woman was scary.

Catra pushed herself away from her desk and stood up. She turned to face her closet, where her Spiderwoman suit was waiting for her. It was about time for her to actually start being a superhero.

Catra suited up, and swung out her bedroom window.

Catra was resting on the top of the Moon Building, eating a fresh bagel with cream cheese. This was a pretty damn good bagel, she'd have to get one of these again.

All of a sudden, the street below literally exploded with activity. Black SUVs with tinted windows sped down the road. They must have robbed the nearby bank or something. Catra stood up, preparing to swing down into action, when something unexpected happened.

"Catra! The Bright Moon General Bank on 56th and Medium was just robbed!" Entrapta's voice shouted into her ear.

Catra nearly fell off the edge. "Entrapta what the fuck! You never told me you put comms in this!"

"I didn't? I could've sworn I did. Oh well, no matter, there's an active crime!"

“Yeah, I know,” said Catra. “I can see them from where I am. I’m on it.”

Catra leaped from the Moon Building and shot out her web to begin swinging. For a few blocks, Catra swung behind the SUV convoy, steadily gaining ground on the criminals. Once she had managed to catch up to the front SUV, she released her web at the apex of her swing, and let herself fall. She landed on the hood of the SUV, causing the driver to panic and swerve.

Behind him, the other SUVs all swerved and stopped, astonished to see a woman in a red and black suit fall from the sky.

Catra smirked underneath her mask. “Well, I do believe you have some things that don’t belong to you, now don’t you. Drop the guns and come out of the cars with your hands up and we won’t have any issues.”

One of the criminals, a tough looking gal sporting an eyepatch and a black suit with a green tie, stepped out of the SUVs first. “Fuck you, psycho bitch. This money’s ours, and you ain’t getting any!”

She pulled out an SMG and began spraying gunfire at Catra. Catra leaped backwards, out of harm’s way. Once the criminal emptied her magazine, Catra sprayed the gun with her webbing, gumming it up and rendering it useless.

“All right, does anybody else want to try me?” she asked.

Ten goons, all dressed in the same black suit with a green tie, with sunglasses, stepped out of the SUVs.

“Aw fuck me and my big mouth.”

Catra tied them all up with her webbing, and suspended them from nearby light poles. Feeling somewhat cheeky, Catra attached a note to the webbing that read, ‘From your friendly neighborhood Spiderwoman.’

As she was about to swing away, a flash of green on the pavement caught her eye. Stooping down to pick it up, Catra quickly recognized the symbol on the green hexagon.

“Well shit, this just got a lot more complicated.”

Catra pocketed the Horde Force Captain badge and swung away. She was going to need to know. Catra knew she had to talk to Adora.

Chapter End Notes

I have been looking forward to posting this chapter for two weeks! It was torture! And then the semester started and that hit like a truck. I'm pretty excited to see what you all think, though.

Thank you to everyone for reading, you guys lighten up my days. I'm trying to be better at responding to comments, although I feel really weird responding to theory comments because I don't want to give something away too early.

The End of the Beginning

Chapter Summary

> Catra knows there's no avoiding it now, she has to see Adora about that Force Captain badge. If only things weren't so complicated. If only Adora didn't hate her now. If only she didn't still love Adora with all her heart. If only they didn't have to leave their lives behind again.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Hey Adora,” Catra said into the dark, “we need to talk.”

Adora dropped the glass of water in her hand. “Catra? Is that really you?”

“Yeah, it’s really me, dummy.” Catra smiled. “Look, we’ve really gotta talk. This is serious.”

Adora flicked on the lights and turned around. “I can’t hide any bodies for you if that’s what you’re asking-”

Adora’s voice choked off as she saw the green badge in Catra’s hand and her eyes grew wide.

“Please tell me that’s not yours and this is all some kind of bad practical joke Glimmer got you in on.”

“It’s not mine, Adora, but this is no joke. The Horde is here in Bright Moon.”

“Oh, fuck.” Adora sagged visibly. “Do you think they know we’re here?’

“I don’t think so. I was in costume when I, uh, acquired it, and I didn’t recognize any of the goons or the Force Captain.”

“Wait, in costume?” Adora asked.

“Yeah, I uh, sort of, maybe started being a superhero,” Catra said.

Adora smiled, and for the first time in a long time, Catra saw that shine in her eyes. “I- that’s wonderful news, Catra. Really, I’m impressed with how far you came since - “

Catra cut her off, “Don’t mention her. Please. It hurts still, to think of her.”

“Okay. I won’t, I promise. But I know another superhero who can help you fight the Horde. I can send her your number?”

“Yeah that works.” Catra knew there was something Adora wasn’t telling her, but she didn’t want to push things. Catra didn’t want to jeopardize things by pushing for more, that would only end badly

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“So to summarize, you met an old friend from the Horde, told her what was going on, she told you she knew a superhero but didn’t tell you which one, and you could tell she was hiding something from you, and you’re okay with meeting this alleged superhero alone?”

“Yeah, pretty much.” Catra stretched her arms, preparing for her swinging

“Have you considered that it might be a trap?” Entrapta said through the earpiece.

“You don’t know Adora. It’s not a trap. She wouldn’t do that.”

“I don’t know, Wildcat, I don’t trust her.”

“Look, she just wouldn’t, okay. We made a promise. I look out for her, she looks out for me. We may not be close anymore, but neither of us is going to break that.”

Catra jumped off the ledge. She swung from building to building, soaring above the streets of Bright Moon. Ahead of her was the building Adora told her to meet the superhero she knew there. On the roof were three figures.

"I don't like this, Catra." Entrapta sounded very uneasy.

"Drop it, Entrapta," Catra said.

Catra landed on the rooftop with hardly a sound.

"Didn't trust me, She-Ra? Or are these two just your sidekicks?"

"No, no, I trust my source. If she says you're trustworthy, then you're trustworthy. These two, however, are as paranoid as it gets, and didn't trust me when I said we could trust you. So rather than stay behind and support me from base like they normally do," She-Ra directed a pointed glare at the figure to her right, "they decided it would be an excellent idea to tag along, despite having absolutely no field experience."

Catra heard Entrapta and Scorpia muttering in the background, so she turned her comms off. Listening to them jabber would get distracting during the mission.

"Tell me about it, my two yahoos wouldn't stop backseat heroing on the way over, especially after we saw those two."

“Oh my gosh right? Like, hello, who’s been doing the superhero gig longer? I know what I’m doing.”

“Anyways, to the issue at hand. The Horde. I assume our mutual contact at least filled you in on who they are?”

She-Ra shook her head. “Personal experience.”

Catra could sympathize. “Okay, then you know them showing up in Bright Moon is bad news for everybody.”

“Yes.”

“Okay, so what’s our plan of action?” Catra asked

“We find their base, bust in, tie up everyone in there and call the authorities.”

“Okay, Muscles, we’re going to need a better plan than that,” She-Ra blushed at the nickname, “they’re going to be ready, probably for both of us. You’re a very well known superhero and I just took out one of their convoys.”

She-Ra's two sidekicks looked taken aback.

"You took on an entire Horde convoy, on your own? I don't believe it. This has got to be some kind of Horde ploy to capture you, She-Ra," the sparkly one said.

"You better believe it, Sparkles." Catra smirked and her tail twitched with amusement.

"We can trust Spiderwoman, Queen," She-Ra said firmly.

Her sidekick with the bow and arrows looked at her with a knowing look. Catra didn't like that look one bit.

They exchanged email addresses at the meeting, promising to work on a better plan later. Apparently, She-Ra had work in the morning, and email was, according to Entrapta, far more secure than sms messaging. How she overrode the mute, Catra will never understand, but at least she did it for good reasons.

However, Entrapta and Scorpia had figured out that She-Ra had sidekicks, which meant they wanted her to have sidekicks, which meant them. Catra was stopping another Horde robbery attempt when they brought it up again.

“C’mon Catra, let us help! The Horde has been sending more and more goons on every robbery, eventually they’re going to be too many for you to handle,” Scorpia said.

Catra webbed one goon, and swung her into another. “And then I’ll have She-Ra to back me up. And her sidekicks.”

“But what if they’re not there? You said it yourself last night, they’re not always there to back you up,” Scorpia said.

“Ignore drunk me, she doesn’t know what she’s talking about.” Catra dodged a punch from a suited Horde goon. She grabbed their tie and pulled them to the ground, securing them with her webbing. “Besides, you two would be a liability in a fight. Neither of you have any powers, or even know how to fight. You’d only endanger yourselves.”

“That’s not true,” Entrapta interjected. “Scorpia has her tail and her pincers, which according to the legislation legalizing parahuman vigilantism, counts as superpowers, plus she still boxes, so I estimate a 95% chance she could handle herself more than adequately against the mean caliber of Horde minions you’ve been facing, with a 5% uncertainty rating. And I am not a liability in combat, I handled myself perfectly fine in the past, I’ll have you know.”

“I… what in the hell does that mean, Entrapta? Y’know what, I don’t want to know. You still don’t have powers.” Catra tied two Horde goons to a lamp post.

“Yes, but all records indicate that Captain Bow is powerless too! He’s only ever been seen using his bow and numerous trick arrows. Also, I’m rich. That’s got to count for something.”

“Ugh, fine, if it gets you two to shut up while I’m working here, then yes, if Captain Bow doesn’t have powers, then you two can be my sidekicks!”

“Yay, thanks Wildcat!”

“I’ll get to work making us costumes!”

Catra sighed heavily. Those two were going to be insufferable if Captain Bow didn’t have any powers.

“So, Captain Bow, what’re your powers?” Catra leaned onto the building ledge next to where he was staring off at the sunset.

Captain Bow smiled. “I never had any. I was just a close friend of She-Ra and Queen who got tired of them coming home every night covered in bruises and cuts. So I spent some time at the archery range, and started putting my major to work.”

Catra's tail lashed in annoyance. "So what is your major, anyways?"

Captain Bow chuckled. "Mechanical engineering. Makes it easier to make all those trick arrows myself."

"Oh dang, I'm kinda impressed honestly," Catra said.

"Thanks, they took a lot of hard work, especially at the beginning."

"Yeah, they look like it." Catra twitched her ears.

"So, how do you know the Horde, anyways?"

Catra looked at him in shock.

"The way you flinch when She-Ra mentions the Horde, or when a Force Captain shows up. You grew up in the Horde, didn't you?"

Catra nods, numb from the shock of him figuring out something she hadn't even told Scorpia.

“Yeah, Adora and I grew up together in the Horde as orphans. It wasn’t perfect, actually it was kinda awful, but so long as we had each other, it was okay. Nobody could really hurt us.”

Captain Bow nodded.

“But Adora was always kind of an idiot, y’know? She never really realized what the Horde was about, what it was doing, and so when she did, she wanted to leave, had to leave. I almost didn’t go with her, but that night destroyed our friendship. I was always so afraid of telling her that I wanted her more than as a friend that when things really mattered, I hesitated too much. She has to hate me now, and I’m still stuck loving her.”

“I don’t think she hates you, Spiderwoman. Adora was always sad, for as long as I’ve known her. I think she’s been missing you, misses you still.”

Catra blanched as she realized the implications of his words. She had really fucked up now.

“Don’t worry, I won’t tell anybody what you’ve told me. Your secret’s safe with me.”

Catra’s ears twitched at an odd mechanical noise from behind her. She and Captain Bow both turned around, and they found a six legged mechanical insect bearing the Horde symbol. It skittered

over to the edge of the building and jumped off before they could catch it.

"Well shit, that's bad," said Captain Bow.

"Yeah, no kidding."

"Let's call the others, maybe they'll know what to do."

Catra paced in the penthouse on top of the Dryl Industries tower. She really hated this, but she supposed it was her only option. Revealing that much about her past was stupid. Really, really stupid. The Horde definitely had enough to get some dirt on her.

The elevator dinged, and Scorpia and Entrapta walked in, with guests. Behind them walked a pair who definitely were the civilian identities of Queen and Captain Bow, and behind them walked Adora.

"Hey, Catra," she said.

"Adora, what are you doing here? This is going to be really dangerous," Catra said.

“I know. I want to be here for you. You look out for me, and I look out for you, remember? It’s about time someone had your back out there.” Adora shifted to reveal the sword she was carrying.” Besides, it’s not like I’m helpless.”

“You’re She-Ra? Really, Adora?”

“Yeah.” Adora at least had the grace to look ashamed. “Look I didn’t know how you felt about me, and I didn’t want to make things awkward. I know how much Bright Moon means to you, and I could guess what saving it might mean for you.”

“So, are we all here and ready to begin?” said Captain Bow.

“Nope, we’re waiting on at least two more!” said Entrapta.

“Don’t you need to tell Baker and Busgirl to let them in?”

“Nope!” Entrapta replied as she jumped into a chair. “They know each other already.”

A few minutes later, when the elevator doors opened again, everyone but Entrapta stood up in shock.

“Dryl, good to see you again. How’s college going for you?” said Major Wind.

“Oh it’s going great, Major! I made new friends, look!” Entrapta pointed to Scorpia and Catra.

Adora, Captain Bow and Queen all tripped over themselves in the shock of seeing the original Bright Moon superhero, probably something of an idol to the three of them, just walk into the room and begin casual banter with Entrapta. Catra laughed a little at their shock, and then she saw who was standing behind Major Wind.

“Professor?” she asked.

“Call me Nets for now, Spiderwoman,” responded Professor Netossa.

Catra hung upside down outside the Horde base. If they could erase the Horde’s recording before it got into their systems, she might manage to protect herself. Even if the Horde didn’t try and hold her secret identity hostage, they would definitely send goons after her. She couldn’t afford to fight Horde goons while also trying to keep everybody else in the dorms safe.

They only had one shot at this. If Shadow Weaver or any of her lieutenants got their hands on that bot, Catra would have to move again. And Adora, big dork that she was, would go with her. Catra couldn't do that to her, not again. She had to get this right.

"It looks all clear, we're good to go." Catra swung back up to the rooftop.

What she saw there stunned her. Catra was speechless for several seconds. Also atop the rooftop stood Scorpia and Entrapta. But rather than the jackets she might expect for the cold weather, they both wore armored suits. Scorpia's armor looked like a modern suit of armor, if covering more areas than most these days. Entrapta had a whole two extra appendages coming off her headpiece.

"What on earth are you two wearing?"

"Oh! These are our super suits! Scorpia's enhances her strength so that she's a match for you, and she also has electrodes attached to her pincer gloves so she can zap someone to knock them out! My suit is mostly armor and mobility, with these two extra limbs for extra grappling security!"

"And Catra, get this! We all have matching themes! You're a spider, I'm a scorpion, and Entrapta's a mite! We're all arachnids! Isn't that great?"

Catra knew her disappointment had to be visible through her mask.

"Are you fucking kidding me? We're all matching. Really. That's what you went with? Even though Entrapta doesn't follow the 'arachnids have eight legs' rule?"

"Yup! Since we're your sidekicks and all that! Also, not all mites have eight legs, some have six legs even into adolescence!" said Entrapta

Catra nestled her face in her palms. Her friends were such dorks. And nerds, they were definitely nerds.

Catra stuck to the ceiling, Entrapta following behind her. Those two extra limbs were pretty handy when climbing, as it turned out. Catra and Entrapta were infiltrating the Horde base first, to try and find the data before everyone else came in, and make the whole operation look like a simple bust. Hopefully they'd be able to keep Shadow Weaver or her mysterious boss from figuring out the real reason behind the raid.

Their best bet to see if the data had gotten out was to try the central database, and if the data was in there, purge it. If the information had spread beyond there, or if Shadow Weaver had seen it, Catra was screwed.

After what quickly became an uncomfortable several minutes, Catra and Entrapta reached the room where the Horde kept their central database. Shadow Weaver had never been great with tech, and it seemed no one had bothered to instruct her in the years since.

When Catra dropped into the door of the central database room, however, she was in for an unpleasant surprise.

“Hello, Catra,” said Shadow Weaver, “you always were a disappointment, you know?”

“Shadow Weaver,” Catra hissed.

The door slammed shut behind them.

“Always so incompetent. You went off to prove yourself, to make Adora proud of you, but you couldn’t even keep your secret identity secret. And here, you dragged your only friend into this mess with you. Will you ever learn that you are just a burden on those around you? That eventually they will see you for what you truly are?”

The building shook with explosions, and under her mask, Catra smiled. “No. I’m not afraid that my friends will see me the way you do, or that they’ll leave me behind. Because they’re my

friends, my family. They've already seen under the mask I wear, and have chosen to stand by my side regardless. Love isn't conditional, like you taught us it was. I look out for them, they look out for me."

Shadow Weaver pooled her magic in her hands. Catra readied her webslingers, and behind her, the ends of Entrapta's additional limbs spun at an alarming rate. The tension held for one fragile second, before Shadow Weaver sent both her blasts towards Entrapta.

The blasts splashed off harmlessly, and Entrapta cackled.

Catra fired her webslingers at Shadow Weaver's hands. If she managed to restrain Shadow Weaver, then she wouldn't be able to use her powers on Catra or Entrapta. One web connected, and it tangled that hand in webbing, rendering it powerless.

Shadow Weaver traced a glyph in the air with one hand radiating shadows. Before she could cast whatever insidious spell she had planned, a glowing sword burst through the door, followed by two bright red pincers.

Catra smiled at Shadow Weaver, knowing it was a pointless gesture. "Well, it would seem like the cavalry's here. Ready to give up yet?"

“I will never surrender to you,” Shadow Weaver spat. She flicked her free hand, and dissolved into shadows just moments before Adora and Scorpia leaped into the room.

“Hey,” Catra said. “She figured it out. My secret identity’s not so secret any more. I’m gonna have to move again.”

“Nonsense, Catra, you can just come live in my place! I have excellent security, and if the Horde comes, well, nobody but us would actually live there, so there wouldn’t be anyone helpless in the way!”

Catra was touched at the gesture. “What about all your employees? I can’t endanger them!”

“Oh don’t worry about them, I have excellent evacuation plans in place.” Entrapta stressed the word evacuation a little bit too much for Catra’s comfort, but it was a place to live.

Adora reached out and put an arm around Catra. “Whatever you choose, I’ll support you.”

Catra smiled, and reached back.

Chapter End Notes

The Super Pal Trio and the Best Friends Squad will return...

AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHHH! I'm so excited to get this out to you guys! I've been waiting for this for what feels like ages! (it's been like, a month).

Once again thanks to everyone who has read, subscribed, kudosed or commented! I cannot thank zeroan enough for all the help he gave me in editing this chapter (and the probably not insignificant inspiration his RSU had on this). If y'all liked this (and also like RWBY) I'd recommend checking it out while you wait for the next installment in this series. (The mans himself: https://archiveofourown.org/users/Zeroan)

School has been kinda unpleasant, not gonna lie, but I've been making serious progress on something I would say is out of my usual wheel well (that new fic I mentioned last week). I hope to actually finish it before my backlog runs out, and we'll have it out then, but I don't really know. It's shaping up to be a long boi. I am still working on Night Running,

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!